Wiltshire County Chess Association

League Rules

These rules apply unless specifically modified for an individual competition.

1 Play shall be governed by the FIDE Laws of Chess unless they are specifically modified by these rules.

2 The League Secretary has responsibility for overseeing the running of the leagues and for resolving issues that may arise.

Possible abuses to these rules should be reported to the League Secretary within 14 days of their occurrence.

An appeal against a decision of the League Secretary should be made within 14 days of receipt of that decision.

The League Secretary will refer the appeal to the WCCA Appeals Committee, whose decision will be final.

3 Matches in the Major, Intermediate and Minor leagues shall be played over 4 boards, with the away team having white on the odd numbered boards. Extra boards may be played which will be rated but will not count in the match result.

4 Immediately prior to the start of a match, captains shall exchange team lists. Teams should be arranged in approximate order of strength with the strongest player on board 1.

5 Every effort would be made to begin games on time, at 7.30pm. No penalty would normally be imposed within five minutes of a breach. Beyond five minutes, a captain will have the right to impose the penalty. The home team are responsible for the provision of equipment including clocks. Except for braille clocks, digital clocks should be used whenever available from the home club.

The time control is 1½ hours for the complete game.

6 Any known default(s) should be on the lowest board(s). Penalty points will be imposed for defaulted boards;

5 points on board 1, 4 points on board 2, 3 points on board 3, 2 points on board 4, 1 point for every arranged extra board.

For every 10 penalty points imposed 1 match point will be deducted.

Penalty points do not apply to matches defaulted in advance.

7 If a player fails to arrive before 30 minutes has elapsed on his/her clock then the opposing team may claim a win by default.

A reserve may replace an absent player providing this is done prior to a claim being made. Penalty points will not be imposed on a player who arrives after a claim has been made but before the end of the match.

8 At the end of the match, captains should sign both copies of the result sheet.

These should be sent to the League Secretary, to arrive within 14 days of the match.

9 If a fixture is postponed then a new date should be arranged. This date should be decided upon, and the League Secretary notified, within 14 days of the original date. The re-arranged date should be within six weeks of the original date. The League Secretary will default both teams if he fails to receive the results of a match or notification of a re-arranged date within 14 days.

10 Eligibility to play in the Major league is open to all members of the club concerned.

Players in any league would be encouraged to have ECF individual membership (minimum Bronze membership).

11 Eligibility to play in the Intermediate League is restricted to club members with an ECF August original rating of 1800 or below (Minor League 1550), or ELO (or equivalent) rating of the same value. Unrated club members are eligible. Unrated members who have previously had a published rating are also eligible provided that their last published rating was no higher than the relevant value shown above. In all cases where players have both an ECF and an ELO (or equivalent) rating the ECF rating will take precedence. All league players will be deemed non-rated unless and until they have a rating based on at least five rated games. Eligibility for the whole season will be based on the August original rating, with the exception that, if a member is deemed **non-rated** in the August list but their first rating (minimum of five rated games) is over 1900 (Minor League 1600), then he/she will no longer be eligible for that league for the remainder of the season (although games already played and results obtained will count). Other monthly ratings will not be considered during the season.

The League Secretary has discretion to relax the letter but not the spirit of these restrictions.

12 A player, who is a member of both clubs, may play for one club in one league and the other club in a different league. Ie for one club in the Major league and the other in the Minor league.

13 When clubs enter two or more teams in a league, it is assumed that Team A is stronger than Team B, which, in turn, is stronger than Team C, etc. Team strength will be determined by the sum of individual ratings or estimates thereof.

Where a club has two or more teams in a league, it should nominate, for all but the lowest team, three regular players who will not normally be eligible for a lower team. In the absence of such a nomination the players on boards 1-3 in that team's opening fixture will be deemed to be nominated. Players named in four matches for a higher team will also not normally be eligible for the lower team. A player not eligible may make one guest appearance for the **next** lower team to avoid a default. (ie guest from A to B or B to C, but NOT A to C). Only one ineligible player may play for a team in any one match. This is intended as an emergency replacement scheme

and not as a regular or tactical occurrence.

14 Positions in leagues will be decided in favour of:-

a) The team with the highest number of match points; 2 for a win, 1 for a draw.

b) The team with the highest number of game points; 1 for a win, 0.5 for a draw.

c) The results of matches involving teams tied on the above.

d) The team with the fewest penalty point imposed.

e) The elimination of the game point scores on the lowest board on which a difference exists.

15 If there is a sound from a mobile phone during play, the owner will donate £1 to the home club funds, and the game be allowed to continue. If this happens a second time during the season it will result in the loss of the game.

16 Entries should be made at or before the WCCA Executive Committee Meeting in September, where the format for that

season will be decided. This meeting is also empowered to adjust the ECF 1800 restriction for the Intermediate league and 1550 for the Minor league.

17 Changes to these rules may only be made at the WCCA Annual General Meeting; such changes should be proposed and

seconded and received by the WCCA Secretary no later than 31st March.

2026-27 season arrangements

Fixtures

- Club unavailability dates supplied to the Fixtures Secretary have been avoided, including all Trowbridge Somerset fixture dates, Trowbridge Club Championship dates, and the two weeks requested by Devizes.
- Teams from the same club are not scheduled on the same day unless they are playing each other. This includes potential clashes between Open and Minor teams.
- The first fixture week begins on 12 October 2026.
- The current fixture list runs to 4 May 2027.
- A two-week break is allowed over Christmas and New Year.

Match format

- **Open League** matches are played over **five designated league boards**.
- **Minor League** matches are played over **four designated league boards**.
- Any additional games may be recorded as spare boards, but do not count towards the official match result or league table.

Minor League eligibility

- For the **2026-27 season**, the Minor League is for players with an ECF August original rating of **1550 or below**.
- This confirms the 2026-27 Minor League limit and supersedes the previous 1500 reference in the archived rules.

Match start and time controls

- As agreed and minuted at the WCCA EGM, all clocks start promptly at 7.30 pm.
- The standard league time control is 75 minutes plus a 10-second increment per move.
- For home matches at Chippenham, the time control is 90 minutes for the game, with no increment.
- In the Minor League only, when ChessMax juniors play away at Trowbridge or Devizes, the time control is 60 minutes for the game, with no increment.